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# Troy School District

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**Report to the Board of Education  
June 30, 2021**



To the Board of Education  
Troy School District

We have recently completed our audit of the basic financial statements of Troy School District (the "School District") as of and for the year ended June 30, 2021. In addition to our audit report, we are providing the following results of the audit and informational items that impact the School District:

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We are grateful for the opportunity to be of service to Troy School District. We would also like to extend our thanks to Mr. Rick West, Ms. Kandice Moynihan, and the entire business office for their assistance and preparedness during the audit. We recognize that preparing for the audit is carried out in addition to your staff's normal daily activities and appreciate their time and dedication. Should you have any questions regarding the comments in this report, please do not hesitate to call.

*Plante & Moran, PLLC*

October 5, 2021

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## Results of the Audit

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October 5, 2021

To the Board of Education  
Troy School District

We have audited the financial statements of Troy School District (the "School District") as of and for the year ended June 30, 2021 and have issued our report thereon dated October 5, 2021. Professional standards require that we provide you with the following information related to our audit.

### **Our Responsibility Under U.S. Generally Accepted Auditing Standards**

As stated in our engagement letter dated June 2, 2021, our responsibility, as described by professional standards, is to express an opinion about whether the financial statements prepared by management with your oversight are fairly presented, in all material respects, in conformity with U.S. generally accepted accounting principles. Our audit of the financial statements does not relieve you or management of your responsibilities. Our responsibility is to plan and perform the audit to obtain reasonable, but not absolute, assurance that the financial statements are free of material misstatement.

As part of our audit, we considered the internal control of the School District. Such considerations were solely for the purpose of determining our audit procedures and not to provide any assurance concerning such internal control.

We are responsible for communicating significant matters related to the audit that are, in our professional judgment, relevant to your responsibilities in overseeing the financial reporting process. However, we are not required to design procedures specifically to identify such matters.

Our audit of the School District's financial statements has also been conducted in accordance with *Government Auditing Standards*, issued by the Comptroller General of the United States. Under *Government Auditing Standards*, we are obligated to communicate certain matters that come to our attention related to our audit to those responsible for the governance of the School District, including compliance with certain provisions of laws, regulations, contracts, and grant agreements; certain instances of error or fraud; illegal acts applicable to government agencies; and significant deficiencies in internal control that we identify during our audit. Toward this end, we issued a separate letter dated October 5, 2021 regarding our consideration of the School District's internal control over financial reporting and on our tests of its compliance with certain provisions of laws, regulations, contracts, and grant agreements.

### **Planned Scope and Timing of the Audit**

We performed the audit according to the planned scope and timing previously communicated to you in our meeting about planning matters on August 13, 2021.

### **Significant Audit Findings**

#### ***Qualitative Aspects of Accounting Practices***

Management is responsible for the selection and use of appropriate accounting policies. In accordance with the terms of our engagement letter, we will advise management about the appropriateness of accounting policies and their application. The significant accounting policies used by the School District are described in Note 2 to the financial statements.

No new accounting policies were adopted, and the application of existing policies was not changed during 2021.

We noted no transactions entered into by the School District during the year for which there is a lack of authoritative guidance or consensus.

We noted no significant transactions that have been recognized in the financial statements in a different period than when the transaction occurred.

Accounting estimates are an integral part of the financial statements prepared by management and are based on management's knowledge and experience about past and current events and assumptions about future events. Certain accounting estimates are particularly sensitive because of their significance to the financial statements and because of the possibility that future events affecting them may differ significantly from those expected. The most sensitive estimates affecting the financial statements were the School District's share of the MPSERS net liabilities for the pension and other postemployment benefit (OPEB) plans recorded on the government-wide statements related to GASB Statement Nos. 68 and 75, respectively. The School District's estimates as of June 30, 2021 were \$308,094,061 and \$48,088,931 for the pension and OPEB plans, respectively, based on data received from the Office of Retirement Services. We evaluated the key factors and assumptions used to develop the accounting estimates in determining that they are reasonable in relation to the financial statements taken as a whole.

The disclosures in the financial statements are neutral, consistent, and clear.

#### ***Difficulties Encountered in Performing the Audit***

We encountered no significant difficulties in dealing with management in performing and completing our audit.

#### ***Disagreements with Management***

For the purpose of this letter, professional standards define a disagreement with management as a financial accounting, reporting, or auditing matter, whether or not resolved to our satisfaction, that could be significant to the financial statements or the auditor's report. We are pleased to report that no such disagreements arose during the course of our audit.

#### ***Corrected and Uncorrected Misstatements***

Professional standards require us to accumulate all known and likely misstatements identified during the audit, other than those that are trivial, and communicate them to the appropriate level of management. Management has corrected all such immaterial misstatements.

#### ***Significant Findings or Issues***

We generally discuss a variety of matters, including the application of accounting principles and auditing standards, business conditions affecting the School District, and business plans and strategies that may affect the risks of material misstatement, with management each year prior to our retention as the School District's auditors. However, these discussions occurred in the normal course of our professional relationship, and our responses were not a condition of our retention.

As required by 2 CFR Part 200, we have also completed an audit of the federal programs administered by the School District. The results of that audit are provided to the Board of Education in our report on compliance with requirements applicable to each major program and on internal control over compliance in accordance with 2 CFR Part 200 dated October 5, 2021.

#### ***Management Representations***

We have requested certain representations from management that are included in the management representation letter dated October 5, 2021.

October 5, 2021

***Management Consultations with Other Independent Accountants***

In some cases, management may decide to consult with other accountants about auditing and accounting matters, similar to obtaining a second opinion on certain situations. If a consultation involves application of an accounting principle to the School District's financial statements or a determination of the type of auditor's opinion that may be expressed on those statements, our professional standards require the consulting accountant to check with us to determine that the consultant has all the relevant facts. To our knowledge, there were no such consultations with other accountants.

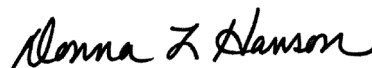
**Other Information in Documents Containing Audited Financial Statements**

Our responsibility for other information in documents containing the School District's financial statements and report does not extend beyond the financial statements. We do not have an obligation to determine whether or not such other information is properly stated. However, we read the Annual Comprehensive Financial Report, and nothing came to our attention that caused us to believe that such information, or its manner of presentation, is materially inconsistent with the information or manner of its presentation appearing in the financial statements.

This information is intended solely for the use of the Board of Education and management of the School District and is not intended to be and should not be used by anyone other than these specified parties.

Very truly yours,

**Plante & Moran, PLLC**



Donna Hanson, CPA  
Partner



Michael Walsh, CPA  
Manager

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## Informational Items

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### **A Year Like No Other**

The past year has been challenging for everyone, particularly those who have continued to keep our schools running throughout this pandemic. While some businesses and employees were able to seamlessly transition to the work-from-home environment, educators and administrators faced a number of hurdles. The School District has faced a continuously changing environment during the pandemic. New federal grants and targeted state funding have placed new accounting and compliance requirements on the School District. Planning will become increasingly important to put the School District in the best position to take advantage of the substantial new, nonrecurring resources provided.

We have worked closely with state and federal decision-makers throughout the pandemic. As the School District's strategic partner, our goal has been to advocate for school districts by meeting with these decision-makers before actions are finalized so that these groups can be well-informed of the implications their actions will have on the School District, your business office, and your financial statements. New or revised accounting and compliance guidance continues to be released from numerous agencies, and school districts are left with the task of deciphering this information to ensure adherence to these new requirements. To that end, as guidance is updated and opportunities are identified, we will continue to work with the School District in navigating the complexities and make sure that your team is always aware of the most current information that impacts the School District. We want to recognize the hard work that everyone at the School District has put in over the past year. We appreciate all that you have done for the students in your communities, and we want to thank you for the opportunity to work with your team during these difficult times.

### **State Aid Funding**

#### ***Background***

**From 18 Months of Financial Uncertainty to Projected Stability:** Since the winter of 2020, the factors surrounding school funding have been uncertain, difficult to predict, and even more difficult to manage.

- **Pre-pandemic:** Prior to the onset of the pandemic, the State's financial resources were stable, predictable, and suggested a predictable, improving financial picture for Michigan schools.
- **Financial Concerns during the Onset of the Pandemic:** During the spring of 2020, predictions were made that there would be significant negative impacts to the State's School Aid Fund and the potential for substantial proration of state aid for school districts due to the grinding halt that the pandemic placed on Michigan's economy. The specific impact was difficult to predict, resulting in two Revenue Estimating Conferences: the normally scheduled one in May 2020 and an additional conference in August 2020. The May conference suggested substantial proration would need to occur (estimated at \$685 per pupil), and many districts adopted a final budget amendment in 2020 to reflect this estimate. By August 2020, the economic impacts of the pandemic were slightly clearer, and the result was a proration of \$175 per pupil for the 2019-2020 fiscal year. While significant, it was much less than what was predicted in May 2020.
- **Federal Resources:** Beginning in March 2020, the federal government initiated financial assistance that directly impacted school districts, with the funding being provided in several waves throughout 2020 and 2021. As is the case with most federal resources, unique spending requirements were attached; however, the guidance and stipulations continued to evolve and change. This resulted in significant uncertainty throughout the year in terms of how and when to expend the available funds. Ultimately, the COVID-19 relief funds did provide more flexibility in spending than traditional federal grants.
- **2020/2021 State Funding:** With a more predictable revenue stream into the School Aid Fund, sustainable school funding was put in place. The foundation allowance was held at the 2019-2020 level, no prorations were required, and a \$65 one-time per pupil payment was provided to school districts. The State also provided additional funding to those districts that did not receive a minimum threshold of per pupil funding from the new Educational Stabilization Fund federal program.



- **2021/2022 State Funding:** Stability within the School Aid Fund continues to improve, and the fund was predicted to have a surplus for the fiscal year ended 2021 and would have sustainable revenue looking out the next few years. This provided the governor and Legislature an opportunity to increase the State's investments in public education. The most significant outcome from their efforts was improved equity in the foundation allowance funding. All schools will be at the target foundation allowance of \$8,700 per pupil. This means the equity gap between the base foundation and the target foundation has finally been eliminated. In addition, all schools, including hold harmless districts, will receive at least a \$171 per pupil increase. In addition, funding progress was made related to recommendations resulting from the School Finance Research Collaborative, which includes increased funding levels for special education; At-Risk; wraparound services, such as nurses and counselors; and Great Start School Readiness (GSRP).
- **Looking Forward:** The most recent Revenue Estimating Conference estimates that the School Aid Fund will remain healthy when projecting out the financial picture over the next few years. Based on the current facts and circumstances, it is expected there will be room for continued foundation allowance funding increases over time, in addition to the ability to invest in specific programming or educational support. However, the key funding lesson from the last 18 months is that predictions are a best estimate based on the current facts and circumstances, and those estimates can be significantly impacted by subsequent events.

#### ***2021 Funding Implications for the School District***

**2020-2021 Foundation:** Due to pandemic-related funding concerns, foundation allowance levels were maintained at 2019-2020 levels. The target foundation allowance (formerly known as the basic foundation allowance) was \$8,529. The minimum foundation allowance remained at \$8,111; however, the School District did receive a one-time per pupil payment of \$65. This was not added to the foundation allowance formula and was not retained for 2021-2022.

**A Unique 2020-2021 Pupil Count:** In order to smooth the impacts of reduced pupil counts during the remote learning period, a temporary one-year change was made to the pupil count method used for the purpose of the foundation allowance formula. For 2020-2021, a super blend was used, combining the pupil counts from the 2019-2020 school year and the 2020-2021 school year. The 2019-2020 count was weighted at 75 percent, and the 2020-2021 count was weighted at 25 percent. This blended pupil count was multiplied by the foundation allowance per pupil to determine the School District's total foundation allowance funding for the year.

**MPSERS Cost Support:** Amounts contributed by the School District to the retirement system are computed as a percentage of payroll. The required contribution rate applicable for all school districts continues to increase. The estimated contribution rate for 2020-2021 ranged from 35.47 to 42.72 percent, with the rate, net of state funding support, paid directly by the employer, ranging from 20.96 to 28.21 percent. The State's funding support is provided in three separate sections of the State Aid Act: Sections 147a, 147c, and 147e. The School District received a total of \$1,070,809 in 147a1, \$1,838,621 in 147a2, \$11,658,202 in 147c1, and \$206,687 of 147e. In general terms, this means the total cost of the retirement system contributions in 2020-2021, representing approximately 42 percent of covered payroll, is recognized as an expenditure in the School District's financial statements, along with related revenue that was previously considered state support to the system. The net effect is that the School District is responsible for approximately a 28 percent contribution to the retirement system.

**Coronavirus Relief Fund (CRF):** At the close of the 2019-2020 school year, there was significant confusion regarding availability and use of CRF. In the summer of 2020, approximately \$362 per pupil was provided to school districts from the Michigan Department of Education through the summer state aid payments. The total available for the School District was \$4,588,959. Even though these funds were received with the final state aid payments for the 2019-2020 school year, since the funding was not approved until July 2020, the funds revenue recognition was required to be deferred and not recognized as revenue until fiscal year 2021. Similar to other federal grants, there were requirements for how the funds can be used, and the School District would determine usage by applying the guidelines. For the year ended June 30, 2021, the School District fully expended the award and recognized the related federal revenue.

**Pandemic-related Federal Funding:** Since March 2020, several iterations of federal funding impacting school districts have occurred. Two key funding sources include the Education Stabilization Fund (ESF) and the Coronavirus Relief Fund (CRF). Each fund provides resources under multiple programs. The principal programs under ESF are the Elementary and Secondary School Emergency Relief (ESSER) Fund and the Governor's Education Emergency Relief (GEER) Fund. CRF programs include the \$362 per pupil passed through by the MDE in addition to some school districts receiving certain funding made available from other nonfederal entities. The common elements to all these revenue sources are that the funds are designed to assist with pandemic relief and the School District must have a specific plan for use of the funds. In general, reimbursement claims could reach back to costs incurred as early as March 2020. Program end dates vary depending on when funds were provided and will require school districts to carefully plan for their use.

**ESSER:** School districts are being awarded ESSER grants in three different waves: ESSER I, ESSER II (further divided between phase 1 and 2), and ESSER III. The School District's ESSER I award amount was \$246,411, and ESSER II and III estimates are \$843,258 and \$1,893,840, respectively. School districts awarded ESSER I funds were able to recognize the revenue during fiscal year 2021 to the extent allowable expenditures were incurred to claim for reimbursement in alignment with the federal requirements. Due to the timing of when award letters were issued to school districts for phase 1 of ESSER II, school districts were eligible to recognize this revenue during fiscal year 2021 to the extent that a grant award letter was received by June 30, 2021. Many school districts did not receive their grant award letter by June 30, 2021, and, therefore, the revenue from phase 1 of ESSER II can be recognized no earlier than fiscal year 2022. Phase 2 of ESSER II and ESSER III awards will be made available during fiscal year 2022.

The allocation of ESSER funds is based on the Title I allocation model. The allocation model uses economically disadvantaged demographics to determine the level of funding to be provided to each school district. As a result, some school districts were provided substantial funding from ESSER, while others received substantially less. The Legislature and the governor concluded districts should receive a minimum amount per pupil, and if ESSER did not provide at least that amount per pupil, then funding from the State should provide an equalization payment to bring a district up to the minimum amount. These state funds would follow similar usage requirements as ESSER Fund. The floor amount of funding was \$450 per pupil related to ESSER II. Based on the School District's level of ESSER II funding, the School District qualified for an equalization payment of \$5,036,199, which was received by the School District over the May through August 2021 state aid payments. School districts had the option of recognizing the equalization payment as revenue during fiscal year 2021 but only to the extent that allowable expenditures were being allocated to this restricted state funding source or deferring the revenue and recognizing it during fiscal year 2022. The School District recognized a portion of the equalization payment as revenue in fiscal year 2021 and will recognize the remainder as revenue in fiscal year 2022.

#### ***2022 Funding Implications for the School District***

The May 2021 Revenue Estimating Conference provided an optimistic view of the School Aid Fund's financial picture for 2022, 2023, and 2024. The School Aid Fund is predicted to complete the State's 2021 fiscal year with a fund balance and is expected to continue to generate funding growth from nonfederal sources for the next few years. As a result, amendments to the State Aid Act for the 2022 fiscal year included several additions to the school funding picture. These included:

- **2021-2022 Foundation Allowance:** With the goal of improving equity among school districts, all districts receive at least a minimum level of funding, which was established as the target foundation allowance. Any school district that was not at the target level in 2021 was increased to the new target foundation of \$8,700 per pupil. For districts already at the target, they received a \$171 per pupil increase from the former target level of \$8,529. For the few school districts in the state above the target, those school districts also received the \$171 per pupil increase. For hold harmless districts such as the School District, the \$171 increase is expected to be realized in two pieces: an increase to the foundation allowance of \$115 per pupil and Section 20m funding of \$56 per pupil.

- **ESSER:** As previously noted, the School District will receive certain ESSER awards during fiscal year 2022. Similar to the ESSER II floor of \$450 per student, the State also set a funding floor of \$1,093 per student for ESSER III. These funds follow the same restrictions on allowable use as compared to the ESSER III federal funds. The expectation was that this state-funded equalization payment would be received during fiscal year 2022; however, in recent announcements, it has become known that the federal government is now questioning the legality of this payment, putting this anticipated funding source into question.
- **Pupil Membership Blend for 2021-2022:** Pupil count determinations return to the pre-fiscal year 2021 super blend method for 2021-2022. As it is expected students will be returning to the classroom, it was concluded there was little need for a super blend that was in effect during 2020-2021. As defined in the School Aid Act, the district is required to complete its calendar year spring and fall counts for 2021. The weighting of those counts continues to be at 90 percent of the fall count and 10 percent of the spring count. The computed pupil count will be used to determine the total foundation allowance paid to the School District. Since schools will be transitioning to in-class instruction in the fall, it may be difficult to predict what enrollments might be. Clearly the level of student attendance will have a significant impact on total revenue generated from the foundation allowance.
- **Summer School and Learning Assistance:** As part of the process to return to in-person learning in the fall of 2021, significant emphasis was placed on summer school. As a result, significant resources were made available to school districts for the summer of 2021 to assist in this effort. Resources included federal funding for summer programming, credit recovery, and before- and after-school programming as part of the Elementary and Secondary School Emergency Relief II Fund. In addition, state aid funding was appropriated for innovative summer programming or credit recovery programs. School districts were required to establish a plan to use these funds for supplemental programming.
- **MPSERS Cost for 2021-2022:** The basic structure, including cost support provided by the School Aid Fund, will continue. For 2022, the overall contribution rate is expected to increase to 43 percent from 42 percent, with the net cost to the School District approximating 28 percent. While the net cost to the School District changes marginally, the overall contribution rate increases significantly from 2021. The School Aid Fund implication is that more resources are redirected from the funding of operations to the support of the retirement system funding requirement. As the School Aid Fund's health has improved, there is renewed interest within the Legislature to provide additional resources to reduce the net cost of school district contributions to the retirement system.

#### ***Looking Forward to 2023 and Beyond***

The May 2021 Revenue Estimating Conference provided a look into 2023 and 2024. 2021 has a projected surplus to carry over to 2022, and surpluses are expected for 2023 and 2024. These surpluses are uncharted territory for school funding in Michigan. In the short term, two supplemental funding measures were put in place. Most of the funds provided were related to appropriating federal funds provided to the State for the benefit of school districts. As we have learned from the past, the Revenue Estimating Conferences provide projections based on the best facts in hand. Experience has told us that those facts can change with the potential for both a positive or negative impact on the projections. Factors to monitor as we look into the future include the following:

- The extent of a continuing economic “bounce back” currently experienced by the State
- The impact as federal stimulus provided tails off during the next two years and the extent of state funding to assist in replacing those resources for recurring services
- The success of returning to in-class instruction
- Extent and duration of resources needed to address learning loss resulting from the pandemic
- Short-term and longer-term student enrollment changes resulting from the pandemic

- Personnel shortages and the impact on providing learning-related services
- Potential staffing cost increases
- Cost trends for the retirement system and the extent to which state support is used from the School Aid Fund

The next Revenue Estimating Conference will occur in January 2022. School districts will need to carefully monitor those results and compare projections to the May 2021 conference results. That information will allow school districts to better project the longer-term implications for school funding.

#### ***Grants Management***

Grants have always been a substantive area in school operations. Typical federal programs seen in most districts include Title I, Special Education, and Child Nutrition. These and other programs continue to be important and require significant skill, attention, and time to account for and adequately deploy those resources. With the advent of the pandemic, programs such as ESSER, GEER, and CRF have infused significant new federal resources into the School District. In addition, primarily through supplemental appropriations, the State has provided additional funding focused on pandemic relief. These events have significantly increased the workload, burden, and grants management risk across the School District. Some examples include the following:

- Superintendents and leadership team - Understanding what resources are available, what is required, how it will be measured, and how it will be staffed or equipped
- Board members - Setting policy in response to the pandemic and approving educational initiatives to respond to learning and operational needs
- Business office - Identifying, tracking, communicating, recording, and reporting on grant-related activities, when, in many cases, the rules and processes are unclear at the onset of the programmatic activity
- Staff - Delivering services in a pandemic-related environment
- Procurement - Identifying, initiating, acquiring, and delivering needed materials and equipment
- Information technology - Establishing and maintaining a safe, secure, and functional system so learning is delivered and operations are maintained
- Support services - Transitioning from in-person connection to remote to identify and provide needed support services to students and staff
- Facilities - Installing upgrades, managing building access, cleaning, and PPE

Each of these areas has been significantly impacted by the new grants and the expanded grants management process. Clearly, the reach and implications of pandemic-related funding are extensive. With that reach comes a significant challenge for the School District to ensure that resources, processes, and controls are in place. Most school districts have not been able to add staffing and have been asked to accomplish much of their responsibilities while working remotely for at least a portion of the 2021 fiscal year. As the School District moves into the 2022 fiscal year, we suggest performing a risk assessment of its key processes and controls. This assessment and related action items can help ensure the School District has the pieces in place for an effective and efficient response to the grants management challenges.

#### ***Budgeting Considerations***

The pandemic will have a substantive impact on district budgeting considerations for years to come. This includes both state and federal funding sources.

As we have seen, funding from the School Aid Fund has varied widely over the last 18 months. Fortunately, School Aid Fund projections suggest funding stability through 2024. However, that stability presumes a continually improving financial picture for the State of Michigan. If assumptions do not hold, there is a risk for continued variability in school funding. Any variability would have a direct impact on funds made available for school operations.

Federal funds have been made available in waves since March 2020. As of June 30, 2021, pandemic-related funding has been substantial, but school districts have yet to access all the funds being made available. Primarily, these funds are provided as grants with program end dates laddered through 2024. The terms and conditions of the different grant funding streams are unique. This means schools must plan carefully for the use of funds to both optimize the value received and ensure compliance with the grant requirements. Also, these resources are not recurring, so school districts should carefully consider their use. If funds are used for recurring activities, the School District will need to redirect other revenue once the grant is complete to continue the activity or discontinue the program. Understanding the full value of the resources received through 2024 will have a dramatic impact on the School District's strategic planning efforts and related budget projections.

Budget management in 2021-2022 and beyond includes many new challenges, many not seen previously within school finance. In summary, some key budget focus items school districts should be building into the budget management process include the following:

- Understanding the specifics of pandemic-related federal aid and strategically planning for its use
- Understanding the specifics of pandemic-related state aid provided and strategically planning for its use
- Crafting a multiyear revenue forecast for recurring school operating revenue, including foundation allowance and recurring categorical aid funding
- Projecting and carefully monitoring pupil counts and adjusting budget projections for significant variations
- Assessing payroll-related costs in two categories: recurring payroll costs based on contractual agreements and variable payroll costs resourced with pandemic-related resources
- Identifying and budgeting for one-time uses of federal and state pandemic-related assistance

In summary, plan for 2021-2022 and beyond but understand there are still many moving parts. Continue to be flexible, and plan to adapt to a potentially changing financial and operational landscape.

#### **Michigan Public School Employees' Retirement System (MPERS) - Update on the Plans' Net Pension/OPEB Liabilities**

Similar to the State of Michigan, the MPERS plan has a September 30 year end. With the adoption of GASB Statement Nos. 68 and 75 several years ago, districts have been reporting their share of the MPERS plan funded status in the government-wide financial statements of the district.

At September 30, 2020, the pension portion of the MPERS plan had a net pension liability of approximately \$35 billion. This is an increase from the reported amount of \$33.8 billion at September 30, 2019, an increase of approximately 3.5 percent. This increase meant that, for the year ended June 30, 2021, districts reported a higher net pension liability than they had in the previous year, despite the fact that districts continued to make their required contributions to the plan during fiscal year 2021. One of the primary reasons for the increase in the liability was due to a less than favorable actuarial experience compared to the actuarial assumptions.



At September 30, 2020, the retiree health care portion (OPEB) of the MPSERS plan had a net OPEB liability of approximately \$5.4 billion. This is a decrease from the reported amount of \$7.3 billion at September 30, 2019, a decrease of approximately 26 percent. The valuation of the OPEB liability included a reduction of the health care cost trend rate from 7.5 percent to 7.0 percent, and the plan also experienced a favorable plan experience adjustment related to lower than projected health benefit costs, which had a positive impact by reducing the total liability.

#### **Fund Balance**

This past school year, more than ever, highlighted the importance of having adequate fund balance due to the uncertainty of the state budget and the impact on the foundation allowance. While fund balance for many school districts ultimately increased during the 2020-2021 school year due to COVID-19 relief funding, that uncertainty a year ago led many districts to initially budget for a significant decline in fund balance. The School District benefited from having sufficient fund balance because it allowed the School District to continue to provide an adequate level of programming for the year. It also provided peace of mind by avoiding the need for sudden or drastic reactions to the adverse circumstances.

The 2021-2022 school year will face many challenges that will have a direct effect on the School District's fund balance. The Consumer Price Index (CPI) continues to grow, which will put inflationary pressures on nearly all school districts. Couple that with the budgeting pressures faced with how to spend the COVID-19 relief funds, and business offices will have a lot to consider and plan for when projecting out fund balance for the upcoming school year.

During the 2020-2021 school year, the School District's General Fund revenue exceeded expenditures by approximately \$6,700,000. This resulted in increasing the General Fund fund balance to approximately \$32,700,000 at June 30, 2021. Fund balance goals are often stated in terms of a percentage of total expenditures. As a point of reference, the statewide average for school districts at June 30, 2020 was approximately 15.90 percent of expenditures. Fund balance at the statewide average would approximately equal the School District's average operating costs for an 8-week period. The School District's fund balance percentage is 19.88 percent and equals approximately 10.3 weeks of operation.

#### **Understanding and Managing Potential Threats to Your Data**

Education continues to be one of the top targets for ransomware attacks. Legislation called the "Enhancing K-12 Cybersecurity Act" was introduced in the House in June 2021 and would appropriate \$10 million yearly for two years to fund a program to improve cybersecurity in school districts.

Working remotely during the pandemic has led to a global rise in cyberattacks. School districts shifted to remote learning quickly; in so doing, security controls may have been relaxed. In today's age of continual reports of cyberattacks, school districts need to be aware of where potential risks lie and how they are addressed and communicated to employees and the public.

When it comes to cybersecurity, the human element is still the weakest link and most targeted, as passwords like "August2021" can be easily guessed, and emails continue to trick people into clicking links and opening attachments. Information security is a district-wide issue, not just an IT department responsibility, requiring a combination of people, processes, and technology to effectively secure student, employee, and financial data. Now is the time to take a step back and assess exactly where your data is and the controls surrounding it. Key questions to ask include the following:

- Are our teachers and staff appropriately aware of phishing and other cyberattacks?
- Do you know where all of the various data resides in the school district? Are employees storing district data with personally identifiable information (PII) or data that is subject to FERPA on file-sharing sites or flash drives? Is the data being emailed to personal accounts?
- How secure is your data with at least a portion of your students and teachers working remotely?

Having an external party do an assessment on vulnerabilities may provide additional support to the IT team for initiatives it is implementing, providing peace of mind for the board that vulnerabilities have been assessed and addressed and allowing for confident communication to the public that its student and employee data is secure. If you are interested in discussing this further, we would be happy to continue the conversation.

### **IT Assessment and Planning**

Much of teaching and learning today is predicated on reliable, robust, and secure technology, as well as an effective IT support function. The disruption caused by the pandemic, particularly as it relates to technology use in teaching, learning, and district operations, cannot be overstated. In a matter of weeks, many IT departments shifted from supporting teachers and staff to supporting teachers, staff, students, and parents, resulting in an incredible increase in support requirements. Regardless of how many students have returned to face-to-face learning, the School District's IT support requirements have changed.

This may be a good time to consider an IT assessment that reviews information technology from people, process, and technical perspectives. Areas of focus include governance, IT staff and organization, use of external service providers, service delivery, network and device management and monitoring, cybersecurity policies and procedures, and the technology itself. An IT assessment provides an objective evaluation of current operations with an actionable plan for improvements and enhancements. Many districts use the results of an IT assessment as their action plan for the next two to three years. We would be happy to discuss how we can help.

### **GASB Statement No. 87 - Leases**

This statement is effective for the School District's June 30, 2022 financial statements. The statement requires recognition of certain lease assets and liabilities for leases that previously were classified as operating leases and recognized as inflows or outflows of resources based on payment provisions of the lease. The statement was issued to improve accounting and financial reporting for leases by governments. The statement establishes a single model for lease accounting for both lessees and lessors based on the foundational principle that leases are financings of the right to use an underlying asset. Under this statement, a lessee is required to recognize a lease liability and an intangible right-of-use lease asset on the lessee's government-wide financial statements, and a lessor is required to recognize a lease receivable and a deferred inflow of resources on the lessor's government-wide financial statements. Furthermore, there are additional financial statement disclosures required for the lessee and lessor as a result of the standard.

To adopt the standard, the School District will have to identify and analyze all significant lease contracts to determine the lease asset and lease liability or deferred inflow or outflow of resources that will be required to be recognized upon implementation of the standard. This review should include all existing lease agreements and other contracts that may have embedded lease arrangements that were not previously considered. Other departments outside of the business office may need to be involved in order to properly identify and locate all agreements subject to the new leasing standard. It is important to begin the process of inventorying lease agreements early on to then determine the financial impact upon adoption.

### **Significant Changes Coming to the Auditor's Report Letter Next Year**

In May 2019, the AICPA Auditing Standards Board (ASB) issued Statement on Auditing Standards (SAS) No. 134, *Auditor Reporting and Amendments, including Amendments Addressing Disclosures in the Audit of Financial Statements*. The update, which is the first significant change to auditors' reports in years, requires changes in the form and content of the auditor's report issued as a result of an audit of financial statements in order to provide financial statement users with more meaningful information about the audit process and meaning of auditor opinions. The statement also introduces the potential for auditors to be engaged to report on key audit matters within the opinion letter. These changes will take effect for the first time in your June 30, 2022 audited financial statements.

The significant key changes that you can expect to see in the auditor's report letter next year include the following:

- Revised order for elements of the opinion letter, including moving the auditor's opinion to the top of the letter
- Expansion of information to be included within a basis of opinion section, as well as notification to the user that the auditor is required to be independent of the entity and meet other ethical responsibilities
- Explanation of how misstatements to financial statements are determined to be material
- Addition of definition of reasonable assurance and identifying that the risk of material misstatement due to fraud is greater than the risk due to error
- Enhanced reporting related to going concern, including a description of management's responsibilities when required by the applicable reporting framework
- Description of the auditor's responsibilities, including responsibilities relating to professional judgment and professional skepticism, internal controls, identification of risks of material misstatement to the financial statements, evaluation of accounting policies used, conclusion on the entity's ability to continue as a going concern, and the auditor's communications with those charged with governance
- Introduction of the concept of key audit matters and clarification of the relationship between communication of key audit matters and the use of an emphasis of matter or other matter paragraph
- Alignment of reporting requirements when the audit is conducted under both generally accepted auditing standards (GAAS) and another set of auditing standards or when the auditor's opinion is other than an unmodified opinion

#### **Significant Changes in the Future to the GASB Financial Reporting Model**

Under the current Governmental Accounting Standards Board (GASB) standards, school districts have been reporting using the current framework for approximately two decades. While the current financial statement presentation has worked, the GASB is looking to improve its effectiveness for all governments.

This project kicked off in August 2013. An exposure draft was issued in June 2020 titled "Financial Reporting Model Improvements." The exposure draft comment period ended during February 2021, and, as a firm, Plante & Moran, PLLC provided comments to the GASB on our thoughts of the proposed standards. The GASB's goal is to have final standards issued by June 2022.

Once adopted by the GASB, these new standards will have a significant impact on the accounting and financial reporting for school districts. Currently, school districts account for activity in the funds using the modified accrual basis of accounting. The exposure drafts argue that, under the current model, there is no sufficient framework that ensures that governmental entities are consistently reporting similar types of transactions in their financial statements. They also argue that the time period looked at for certain transactions in fund accounting is too short and that the current method has too many piecemeal guidance points rather than a conceptual framework against which transactions can be applied in order to determine the correct accounting. Some of the proposed changes in the exposure drafts (which are significantly different compared to the current model) include the following:

- Requiring additional information in the management's discussion and analysis (MD&A)
- In the budget-to-actual statements, requiring a column that would show the variances between the original and amended budget



- In the fund-based statements:
  - Significant terminology changes - “Revenue” would be referred to as “inflows of resources” and “expenditures” as “outflows of resources.” In addition, many of the statements will be renamed, and some of the fund-type definitions will be changed.
  - “Modified accrual” accounting would change to “short-term financial resources measurement focus.” Generally, transactions would be accounted for in the governmental funds if they are expected to be converted to cash or paid in cash within 12 months of the school district’s year end. A typical example would be revenue recognition. Under today’s rules, if a receivable is not collected within 60 days of the school district’s year end, then the related revenue, generally, must be deferred until the following year. Under the proposed changes, the revenue can be recognized in the current period as long as it will be collected within one year of the current period end. In this example, revenue in the funds may be recognized sooner in the proposed new model as compared to the current model. This change will impact the timing of when revenue and expenditures are recorded in the governmental funds; in addition, the actual financial statements themselves will actually look quite different from a presentation perspective. This is a significant change.

The exposure draft allows for a phased adoption. Districts with total annual revenue (across all funds) over \$75 million would adopt in the year ending June 30, 2025. Those under \$75 million would adopt in the year ending June 30, 2026. We will continue to monitor progression very closely. When the new standards ultimately get issued, we will work with your business office to ensure smooth and efficient adoption.

A separate but somewhat related project is also ongoing. In June 2020, the GASB released its preliminary views titled “Revenue and Expense Recognition.” The objective of this project is to develop a comprehensive, principles-based model that would establish categorization, recognition, and measurement guidance applicable to a wide range of revenue and expense transactions. When the new standard is issued and adopted, it could result in revenue and expense transactions being reported either earlier or later than they currently are in school district financial statements. The GASB’s current work plan anticipates that this new standard could be issued during 2025.